

HCO Full v2 Policy Rewrite Rulebook

Do's and don'ts for rewriting NABH policy documents in plain language

This is a working reference, built from the actual mistakes caught and fixed while rewriting ROM.1, ROM.2 and ROM.6. Every rule here exists because a real draft got it wrong first. Use this before starting a new chapter, and check every generated draft against it before approving.

1. The Core Principle

A policy rewrite has two separate jobs, and they must not be confused:

- 1 **Structure/formatting** — title format, section order, table layout, bracket rules. This is mechanical and safe to copy from an approved reference document.
- 2 **Content** — the actual rules, obligations, and explanations. This is NOT mechanical. It must be pulled fresh from each standard's own source text (OE + Guidebook interpretation) and checked every single time, even though the pattern looks the same.

Never let confidence in the structure create false confidence in the content. A document can be perfectly formatted and still contain a wrong rule.

2. Content Rules — the ones that actually catch errors

2.1 Match the source's exact strength of obligation

NABH source text uses different modal words on purpose: *shall / must* (mandatory), *may / could* (optional or an example), *should* (recommended). A rewritten rule must preserve that exact strength — never upgrade a "may" into a "must".

DO:

- Pull the raw OE sentence AND the Guidebook interpretation before writing any rule.
- Write out a modal-strength table (which words are shall/may/could) before drafting rules — this was the single most effective check across all three rewrites.
- When a source lists something as one possible example ("could be in the form of a registration certificate"), phrase it as an example, not the only accepted method.

DON'T:

- Don't turn "may require formal orientation" into "Do not skip formal orientation." (Real error, ROM.1 draft 1 — orientation is conditional, not mandatory.)
- Don't turn "selection may be based on qualifications..." into a required criterion. (Real error, ROM.1 draft 1.)
- Don't invent enumerated failure scenarios the source never lists. Example: the ROM.2 source says only "conveys affiliations... in an honest manner" — a first draft invented three specific violation types (applied-for, expired, partial-scope) that don't appear anywhere in the standard.

2.2 Never reuse another standard's sentences or reasoning

Each standard's rules must trace only to its own OE text and interpretation — never copied or adapted from a sibling standard, even when the topics feel related.

DO:

- Run an explicit overlap check before presenting a draft: which sentences also appear in previously-approved documents, and is that overlap genuine shared boilerplate (training sentence, distribution line) or borrowed subject-matter content that belongs to the other standard?
- State the check's result out loud, even if the answer is "no reuse found" — an unverified claim of "no reuse" is not the same as a checked one.

DON'T:

- Don't reuse a chapter-specific exclusion list. Example: ROM.1's list of "what this policy does not cover" was copied wholesale into a ROM.6 draft — wrong duties entirely for that standard.
- Don't let two different standards' Reference sections list the same internal artefacts unless those artefacts genuinely belong to both.

2.3 CORE / asterisk status lives in exactly one place

Objective elements are asterisked (documentation required) or marked CORE (zero tolerance) in the official standards data. This status must survive into the rewritten document — but only once.

DO:

- Put CORE/asterisk status ONLY in a "Level" column in the Traceability table, pulled from the actual inventory JSON (star / level fields) — never transcribed by eye.
- Give Section 7/8 (Quality monitoring) a working cross-reference back to that Level column, e.g. "documentary evidence is on file for each asterisked objective element (marked * in the Level column of Section N)" — and get the section number right.

DON'T:

- Don't write "This objective element is asterisked..." or "This is a CORE objective element..." as inline sentences inside the plain-language "What we do" prose. It breaks the readable voice and duplicates what the Traceability table already states.
- Don't drop the CORE/asterisk marker entirely for readability — the underlying obligation ("evidence on file for each asterisked OE") still needs a real referent somewhere in the document.

2.4 Abbreviations tables are derived, not copied

DO:

- List ONLY abbreviations that actually appear in that specific document's rendered text.
- Derive this mechanically — scan the rendered body (excluding the glossary itself) and keep only abbreviations with at least one real occurrence.

DON'T:

- Don't copy a fixed abbreviations list from a previous chapter's approved document. A governance or ethics policy that lists AERB (a radiation authority) makes the whole document look template-assembled — the opposite of the point of rewriting it.

2.5 The Purpose exclusion line stays generic — no standard-number cross-references

Every Purpose section has a line stating what the policy does NOT cover. Keep this generic and consistent across every standard in every chapter — do not name specific sibling standard numbers.

DO:

- Use the fixed pattern: "This policy does not cover [brief list of topics] — those are covered in other hospital policies. The other [Chapter] standards have their own policies too."
- Keep this identical in structure across every standard in a chapter — ROM.1 through ROM.6 (and every other chapter) should all read the same way here.

DON'T:

- Don't write out specific cross-references like "governance is in ROM.1, ethics is in ROM.2, sustainability is in ROM.3..." — this drifted in partway through the ROM chapter (starting at ROM.3) without being asked for, breaking consistency with ROM.1/2/6's simpler generic phrasing.
- Don't let a chapter's later standards adopt a different Purpose-section convention than its earlier ones — check the most recently approved sibling standard before drafting the exclusion line.

2.6 Never invent a specific date, number, or deadline the source doesn't give

Real error caught in a comparison test: a model asked to fill in a Document Control table invented "Effective Date: October 2026" and "Next Review: October 2027" — plausible-looking, completely fabricated. Nothing in the source data specified any date.

DO:

- Leave a real blank — " _____ " — for any date, effective date, or review date that isn't supplied as part of the source data or explicitly given by the person requesting the document.
- Only state a specific number (a frequency, a deadline, a threshold) when the OE or Guidebook text actually states that number.

DON'T:

- Don't fill in a plausible-sounding date, version number, or interval just because the template has a field for it. An empty field is correct; a fabricated value is not.

2.7 No leftover template boilerplate

DON'T include, unless it appears in an already-approved reference document:

- "This policy covers all N requirements under this standard, listed in detail below." — restates the OE count instead of saying anything useful.
- "Do not skip: [restated OE sentence]" as a non-negotiable rule — this is a label, not a rule.
- "Hospital Name implements X so that [restated OE sentence]" or "This policy says how Hospital Name meets standard X:" — restates the requirement instead of describing what the hospital does.
- Internal build artefacts: md5 hashes, OCR file paths, draft_label values, "Method note (from guidebook interpretation):" — none of this belongs in a document a hospital or assessor reads.

3. Structure and Formatting Rules

3.1 Title

- Format: "Policy on [Subject]" — e.g. "Policy on Those Responsible for Governance".
- Uses the Word "Title" paragraph style — not Heading 1, not plain bold text.
- No chapter/edition subtitle line underneath (e.g. "HCO Full Accreditation, 6th Edition — ROM.2.") — this was explicitly removed from the approved pattern and must not be reintroduced.

3.2 Guillemets (« »)

- Keep « » brackets ONLY around «Hospital Name» — this is the one placeholder the delivery system (personalizedDocx) finds and replaces automatically by searching for the bracketed text.
- Every other placeholder (Medical Superintendent, department in-charge, quarterly, 90 days, etc.) is written as plain text — these are manual-edit defaults, not automated substitutions.

3.3 Staff acknowledgement sentence

- Format: "I have read the Policy on [Subject] of «Hospital Name». I will follow the processes described."
- Do not write "Policy on X policy of Y" — check for this stutter whenever the title changes.

3.4 Section order

In this exact sequence:

- 1 Document control (table)
- 2 Statement of intent
- 3 1. Purpose
- 4 2. Scope
- 5 3. Policy standards
- 6 4. Non-negotiable rules
- 7 5. What we do (with 5.1, 5.2... subsections)
- 8 6. Stop-work authority — only if the standard actually has stop-work data in its source
- 9 7 (or 6). Governance and responsibility (table)
- 10 8 (or 7). Quality monitoring
- 11 9 (or 8). Training and staff acknowledgement (with signature table)
- 12 10 (or 9). Distribution
- 13 11 (or 10). Abbreviations (table)
- 14 12 (or 11). Traceability to NABH HCO Full Accreditation 6th Edition [Code] (table, with Level column)
- 15 13 (or 12). Required Records / Evidence Checklist
- 16 14 (or 13). References — LAST numbered section, immediately before Disclaimer

17 Disclaimer (four fixed paragraphs, not numbered)

References was originally mid-document; it was deliberately moved to sit right before Disclaimer. When section numbers shift because of this move, check every internal "Section N" cross-reference in the document — a Level-column reference or a stop-work reference can silently point at the wrong number after a reorder.

3.5 Word paragraph styles

Element	Style
Main title	Title
Top-level sections (Document control, 1. Purpose, 2. Scope, etc.)	Heading 1
Subsections (5.1, 5.2, etc. within "5. What we do")	Heading 2
Body text	Normal
Non-negotiable rules	List Number
Bulleted lists (References, Evidence Checklist)	List Bullet

Real error caught: a document generated by cloning another file's raw XML had its title on Heading 1 instead of Title, and every top-level section demoted one level to Heading 2. Always verify the actual paragraph style objects, not just how the text looks when skimmed.

3.6 Document control table

- 6 rows × 4 columns: Document No./Version, Issue No./Review due, Date created/Date of implementation, then Prepared by / Reviewed by / Approved by — each spanning the remaining columns as one merged cell.
- Prepared/Reviewed/Approved rows must be actual table rows with merged cells — not separate paragraphs sitting below the table.

4. The Verification Loop — repeat for every standard

This is the process that catches the errors above. Skipping any step is how a wrong rule reaches a finished document.

- 1 **Pull the source.** Get the raw OE text and Guidebook interpretation for every objective element in the standard, verbatim, from the actual source JSON. Never draft from memory or by pattern-matching a previous chapter.
- 2 **Check for truncation/corruption** in the source text before using it. If anything is cut off mid-sentence or garbled, stop and get the real text — don't guess how it ends.
- 3 **Draft** using the approved structure/formatting rules in Section 3, and the content rules in Section 2.
- 4 **Run the overlap check** — explicitly compare the new draft's sentences against every previously-approved document. Report which sentences overlap and why (shared boilerplate vs. borrowed content).
- 5 **Show the raw source text** (OE + interpretation) to the reviewer alongside the draft — not just a summary claiming it was checked. The reviewer needs to see the actual "shall/may/could" language to confirm the rules match it.
- 6 **Review against every rule in Sections 2 and 3** before approving.
- 7 **Generate the file**, then verify the actual paragraph styles and table structure programmatically — don't trust a text-only preview.
- 8 **Open the real file** in Word at least once before treating it as final.
- 9 **Commit with an explicit file list** (never a blanket ``git add .``), confirm staged files with ``git status`` before every commit, and push.

Realistic pace: expect roughly one to two standards fully verified per working session. This is slower than generating many documents at once, but it is the only version of this process that has actually produced a correct document so far.